

Dell XPS 1530

The newer XPS 1530 is Dell's answer to the high-end desktop replacement notebooks in the 14 to 15.4-inch size category. With the same tapered body as the M1330 (although it's not as slim), the M1530 packs even more horsepower under its larger hood. Like up to a T9500 (2.6 GHz) processor, 4 GB of RAM, and an option of a GeForce 8600GT. The same ergonomic keypad makes its way into this one. The wide palm rest (slightly bigger than the already generous M1330) will really (ahem) rest your palms. With features like HDMI, this could also be a substitute for an HTPC.

The M1530 is available with a 15.4-inch screen, but you get to choose the resolution. Choose from 1280x800 pixels, 1440x900 pixels, or a whopping 1680x1050 pixels. If you want something a little more powerful than the XPS M1330, then the 1530 will do the trick. It'll also give you more real estate on-screen. If you crave mobil-

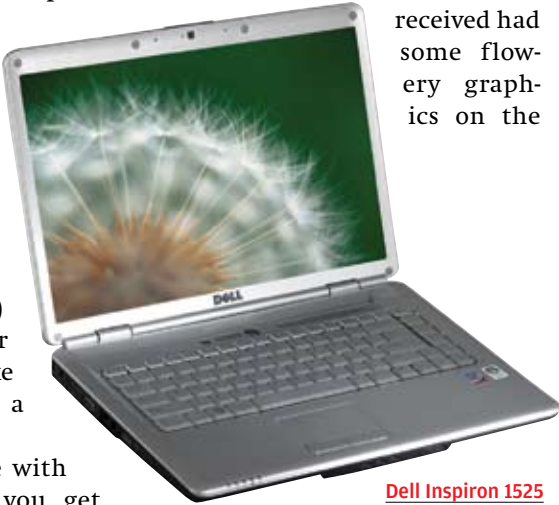


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ity, go with the smaller sibling. Prices start at Rs 49,900, and it's a superb deal overall. The stuck-on panels are a pain, though.

Dell Inspiron 1525

Dell's notebook for the masses, the Inspiron series are their mainstream offerings, a cut below the fancy looking, higher configuration bearing XPS notebooks. With a regular 15.4-inch screen, the Inspiron 1525



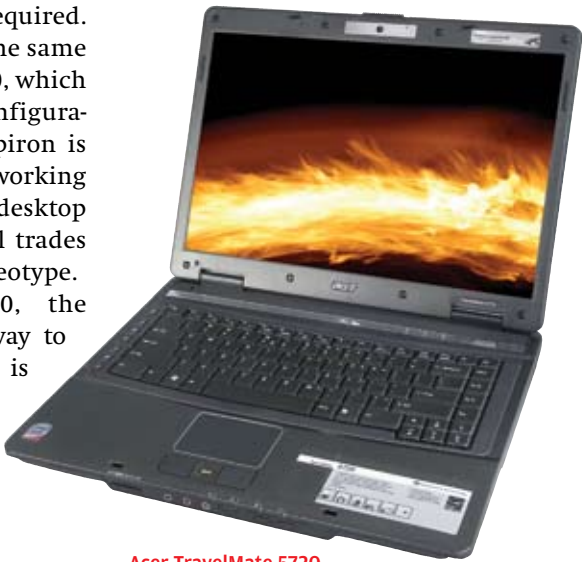
Dell Inspiron 1525

lid—one of many designs available when you configure it online. But it's got a capable configuration that can bare its teeth when required. It's also not as compact as the same screen size bearing XPS 1530, which users who want a higher configuration would prefer. The Inspiron is the proverbial 'rock'. The working man's solution, the home desktop replacement, the jack of all trades and yet master of none stereotype.

Starting at Rs 42,900, the Inspiron 1525 is a cheap way to a good configuration, and is highly recommended to the home user, who wants a desktop replacement. Add in a graphics card for a scant Rs 3,000 more, and you've got yourself a plain-looking but effective powerhouse.

Acer TravelMate 5720

The TravelMate 5720 looks like a business companion at first, with its charcoal grey metal lid, and black body. Bundled with Linux, this is not the typical business laptop, and so



Acer TravelMate 5720

ASUS F5SL

The first thing that struck us when we looked at the laptop while it was closed was "compact 17-inch". Then, we opened her up and saw the bulky bezel and a 15.4-inch screen (sheep in wolf's clothing?). It's built well, and the F5SL is a good looking laptop that has a beautiful charcoal grey

it finds itself in this category—not exactly a bad place to be. One grouse is the size, it's not very wide or long for a 15.4-inch notebook, but it is thick. Thanks to the bullet proofing on the cover, it's also heavy, and feels bulky to lug around.

The innards consist of a fast T7500 (2.2 GHz) and 1 GB of RAM. Needless to say, it's no slouch, but we weren't really impressed. The 120 GB HDD was also a little on the smaller side. What we did like, was the number of USB ports—four of them, and Acer even managed to sneak in a mini FireWire port! In terms of connectivity options, everything possible has been included. So there you go...a complete solution that's not a standout in any way, but neither does it have any serious flaws. For Rs 44,999, the TravelMate 5720 is a little expensive for the configuration. Actually, all they need to do is to make the body slightly slimmer. And add another gigabyte of RAM. Then we'd swallow the deal.



ASUS F5SL

colour. The nicely bevelled keys are well spaced-out, great for typing and feedback is pretty decent. We also loved the touchpad's responsiveness.

ASUS does cheat a bit on the configuration though. A fast, shiny new GPU, paired with an older, slower processor. Although this keeps the price down, it also keeps the F5SL from becoming a serious multimedia enthusiast's solution. Its slightly bulky form means that it's larger than your average 15.4-inch notebook, and will easily replace most desktop PCs. The fact that ASUS supplies a USB mouse with a tilt wheel, just goes to show their level of commitment to try and replace your desktop.

At Rs 44,990, and with good hardware, the F5SL is a solution that's well worth the price. The amount of software bundled, the build quality and the usability of this notebook will be the answer to nearly all home user's prayers.

Sony Vaio VGN-FZ35GN

This 15.4 inch laptop is a beauty to behold, with a slim design well complemented by quality materials and a silver base colour with the palm rest trimmed in dark grey. Although it feels a little heavy, this notebook is built like a tank, and sculpted like a sports car. The keypad is well laid out, although (strangely) not as well laid out as its tiny 11.1-inch sibling. Sony has dropped in an amazing screen, its

bright, brilliant colours, and text is very, very easy to read. After working with mediocre displays, this is a much needed respite.

A killer configuration—Core 2 Duo T8100 (2.1 GHz), 2 GB of RAM, 200 GB 7200 rpm HDD, and a GeForce 8400GT mean that this

Vaio is ready to tackle nearly any obstacle thrown in its path. It's the epitome of what 15.4 inch notebooks are all about—power, performance, looks, build quality, with just a tantalising hint of portability.

The only place Sony slipped up in our opinion, was with the rather lifeless and clicky multimedia keys.



Sony Vaio VGN-FZ35GN

These exude no feedback whatsoever, and they feel tacky as well (although we're sure they aren't). With HDMI and S-Video connectivity the VGN-FZ35GN can substitute as a decent HTPC solution for those who have large screen TVs and wish to hook them up to a computer.

At Rs 59,900, the Vaio VGN-FZ35GN offers a superb configuration and a colossal software bundle as well, making this Vaio really worth its price for those looking for a superbly refined 15.4-inch notebook that can double as a desktop for most tasks.

Fujitsu S7211

Fujitsu's S7211 is a spin-off from their business series. It's ruggedly built, but doesn't share the same class leading weight reduction tactics that Fujitsu employs in their higher "P" series. It's also not as compact as the other Fujitsu 14.1-inch offerings. There's a nifty little LCD display on the top of the notebook, and to the left of the keyboard displays essential parameters like the battery life and status, power saving mode selected and WiFi status. Then there's the keypad, which doesn't feel as ruggedly built or impart the same sort of feedback, though to be perfectly honest feedback wasn't as bad as some of the other notebooks in this category. Only the display is as crisp as the costlier siblings. There are four large configurable shortcut keys atop the front fascia, above the keypad, and to the right, which are useful and easily accessible.

A powerful CPU (T7500, 2.2 GHz) is let down by a 'mere' 1 GB of RAM. Windows Vista Basic is the OS included, as is a full set of software to get you started. Fujitsu scores in the pricing department—at Rs 41,000 the S7211 is very well priced for such a well built, and feature rich notebook. Although some will lament the lack of more memory, we feel the overall package and the notebook itself is worth the premium you pay.



Fujitsu S7211